Agreement between Supervisor/Advisor and Graduate Student

With specific provisions on the use of artificial intelligence

Version 1: Oct 30, 2026 · by Zhuo Chen (zchen1@uga.edu) with assistance from Claude Opus 5.

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1. Purpose and parties

This agreement states the mutual expectations of the supervisor and the student, including the standards governing the use of artificial intelligence in the research. It does not supersede university, funder, or publisher policy; where provisions differ, the official policy prevails. The agreement is reviewed at least annually.

Field	Entry
Student Name / Program	
Supervisor/Advisor Name	
Project area or title	
Start date / expected submission	
Agreement signed / last reviewed	

2. Supervisor commitments

- Meet with the student at the agreed interval, and give advance notice when a scheduled meeting must be rescheduled.
- Return written work with substantive comments within two weeks, and indicate at the earliest opportunity if that interval cannot be met.
- Provide the equipment, data, software, and training the project requires; where a resource is unavailable, identify alternative means of access or explain the limitation.
- Provide candid and timely assessments of progress, recording any concerns in writing as they arise.
- Discuss authorship before the work commences, and support publication, presentation, and professional development.
- Provide letters of reference upon request.

3. Student commitments

- Assume responsibility for the project: set meeting agendas, prepare written progress notes in advance, and read widely in the field.
- Meet agreed deadlines, or give notice early enough for the schedule to be revised.
- **Maintain complete and contemporaneous records of data, code, decisions, sources, and AI use.**
- Comply with all ethical, legal, safety, and funder requirements applicable to the work.
- Submit for feedback only work that the student has read, verified, and can defend as their own.
- Report problems and errors promptly, including those of the student's own making, and acknowledge the contributions of others accurately.

4. Use of AI — four principles

"AI assistance" denotes any generative or machine-learning tool that shapes the content, analysis, or presentation of the work, including language models, coding assistants, AI-based literature search and summarization, translation, transcription, image generation, and automated analysis pipelines that determine methodological choices. Spell-checking, citation formatting, and established non-generative software are excluded.

AI may be used, and in many cases its use is encouraged, subject to the four principles set out below. These principles apply to the supervisor as well as to the student. No AI tool may be listed as an author. Presenting AI-generated material as the student's own unaided work constitutes misrepresentation, however fluent the result.

4.1 Follow institutional rules

- Know and observe the policies of the university, department, funder, publisher, and ethics board, together with the terms of use of the tool itself; where these differ, the most restrictive provision governs.
- Verify the applicable policy at the point of use rather than from memory, and confirm the venue's requirements before each submission, as such policies are revised frequently.
- Where a policy is silent, ambiguous, or in conflict with another, adopt the conservative interpretation, disclose the use, and consult the supervisor before proceeding.
- Assessed work, including examinations, qualifying papers, and coursework, is governed strictly by the relevant assessment regulations; AI use is to be presumed prohibited unless expressly permitted.

4.2 Declare and document AI use

- Disclose AI assistance, together with other approved forms of assistance (editing, translation, statistical consultation, technical support, or borrowed code), to the supervisor as the work proceeds rather than in a single retrospective statement.
- Record each material use in the log described in Appendix A: the date, the stage of the work, the tool and version, the task assigned to it, the output produced, the use made of that output, and the verification performed.
- Retain prompts and raw outputs with the project records, and maintain AI-generated code under version control so that generated and revised versions remain distinguishable.
- Characterize the student's own contribution accurately, neither concealing the tool's role nor attributing to it judgment that was the student's.
- Ensure that the work is reproducible independently of the tool. Because AI output is not deterministic, any AI-assisted procedure must be documented in sufficient detail for another researcher to reproduce it manually or with a different tool.
- Disclose AI use in published work in the form the venue prescribes, and disclose it even where no statement is required if AI materially shaped the work.

4.3 Understand what the AI has done

- The degree certifies the student's expertise rather than the tool's. For any element of a thesis or publication, the student must be able to explain the method in their own words, account for every line of submitted code, justify the underlying mathematics independently, and respond to a skeptical examiner without recourse to the tool.
- The most stringent standard applies to the area the student claims as their expertise. Convenience may justify delegating a peripheral task; it never justifies forgoing the core competencies of the field.
- The use of AI as an aid to learning — for explanations, worked examples, and code read line by line — is encouraged; its use as a substitute for learning is not.
- The supervisor may at any time ask the student to explain or reproduce an AI-assisted component without the tool. Such a request is a routine element of supervision and does not imply an allegation of misconduct.
- No element may appear in the thesis that neither party is able to explain.

4.4 Review what the AI produced

- AI output is plausible by construction and only intermittently correct. Recurrent failure modes include fabricated or misattributed references, confidently stated factual errors, code that executes without error yet computes the wrong quantity, omitted terms in a derivation, summaries that suppress a source's qualifications, uncritical agreement with the student's own proposals, and text sufficiently close to published work to constitute plagiarism.

- Verify every reference against the original source, and every factual claim against a primary source the student has read.
- Read and test all code, using cases with known results wherever possible, and check every statistical result against its assumptions and the plausibility of its effect size.
- Under no circumstances use AI to generate, alter, or impute data, or to modify data figures.
- Revise AI-drafted text sufficiently that the student can vouch for every sentence.
- The student remains accountable for the final product. Attribution of an error to an AI tool constitutes no defense in a thesis defense, in peer review, or in a misconduct proceeding. Errors identified after submission are reported to the supervisor immediately and corrected on the record.

4.5 Confidentiality

Any material entered into an AI tool should be presumed to be retained and therefore disclosed. Personal or participant data, material covered by an ethics approval, unpublished work by collaborators, manuscripts received for confidential peer review, and anything under embargo or non-disclosure agreement are not to be entered into tools that the institution has not approved for that purpose. Where the research requires AI assistance with sensitive material, the supervisor arranges an approved deployment rather than permitting an informal workaround.

5. Permitted, restricted and prohibited uses

The provisions below represent the initial position for this project. They may be amended by agreement, and are superseded by any more restrictive institutional or venue requirement.

Permitted and prohibited uses of AI	Status
Brainstorming, explanation, learning, and practice	Permitted, no declaration
Copy-editing of the student's own text	Permitted, no declaration
Translation; literature search and screening; summarizing papers already read	Permitted; declare and verify at source
Code: boilerplate, refactoring, debugging, and tests	Permitted; declare, read, test, and log
Core analysis code, statistical design, thesis or manuscript prose, figures, responses to reviewers, grant text	Discuss with the supervisor in advance; declare; the student must be able to defend it
Work assessed for the student's own competence	Prohibited unless the assessment regulations expressly permit it
Peer review of others' manuscripts or grants	Prohibited unless the publisher permits it
Confidential, personal, or embargoed data in unapproved tools	Prohibited
Generation or alteration of data and results	Prohibited

6. Meetings, progress and records

Item	Agreed arrangement
Meeting frequency and length	
Written progress notes circulated	
Who records decisions and actions	
Expected response and feedback turnaround	
Out-of-hours expectation	
Teaching or assistantship duties	
Travel, software and publication budget	

- Milestones are agreed annually, and progress is reviewed formally and in writing at least once a year, incorporating the student's own assessment and any concerns regarding supervision.
- Raw data are never overwritten; all processing is performed in scripts, and all code is maintained under version control from the outset.
- Research records — notebooks, scripts, the data management plan, the AI log, prompts, and raw outputs — are maintained as the work proceeds and remain the property of the institution. Upon departure, the student leaves executable code, data in an agreed format, and documentation sufficient for the work to be continued.
- Negative and null results are reported as obtained.

7. Authorship and credit

- Authorship follows the criteria of the discipline or journal, is discussed when the work is planned, and is recorded in writing. The student is normally first author on work arising from their own thesis research.
- No AI tool is credited as an author; AI assistance is reported in the methods or acknowledgments.
- Technical assistance, data provision, editing, funding, and tools are acknowledged accurately, and contributor-role statements are used where the venue supports them.
- The timing and venue of publication are agreed jointly. Intellectual property and commercialization are governed by institutional policy, which is explained to the student at the outset.

8. Integrity, conflict and review

- No data collection begins before the requisite approvals are in place, and both parties maintain current certification in all required training.
- Fabrication, falsification, and plagiarism constitute research misconduct, as does undeclared or prohibited use of AI. An honest error disclosed promptly is treated as an error; one that is concealed is not.
- A suspected breach of Section 4 is addressed first through direct discussion of the work itself. Proportionate responses include repeating the component unaided, correcting a declaration, or undertaking additional training; serious or repeated breaches are referred to the institution's research integrity procedure. AI detection tools are unreliable and are not treated as evidence.
- Disagreements are raised between the parties in the first instance, then with the advisory committee or graduate coordinator, and thereafter through the ombuds, grievance, or union procedures. Recourse to a formal procedure carries no penalty, and either party may request a change of supervisor without prejudice.

- This agreement is reviewed annually, and whenever policy, funding, or supervisory arrangements change materially; amendments are dated and agreed in writing.

9. Signatures

We have read and discussed this agreement, including its provisions on the use of artificial intelligence, and agree to be bound by it.

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Student			
Supervisor			
Co-supervisor			

Appendix A — Example of AI Use Disclosure Statement

Generative AI Use Disclosure

Where such a statement is required, it should read: The author of this dissertation acknowledges the use of generative AI for the following purposes [ADD DETAILS]. This use was reviewed and authorized by the doctoral/thesis advisory committee.

Appendix B — Disclosure of AI Use in Preparing This Agreement

This disclosure is made in accordance with Section 4.2 of the present agreement, which applies equally to the document itself.

Tool and date. Claude (Anthropic), a large language model, accessed on October 30, 2026.

Initial prompt. The first draft was generated in response to the following prompt, reproduced verbatim:

> *Generate a supervisor/student contract with a special focus on AI use*
> *Highlight the following points*
> *1. follow institutional rules*
> *2. declare and document AI use (and approved assistance), what AI has completed, and your contribution -- be honest and make your research reproducible as much as possible*
> *3. understand what AI has done -- you need to learn, especially in the area you are claiming as your expertise*
> *4. review what AI produced -- AI can make mistakes; you will be responsible for what you claim as your product*
> *Please add other components typically included in a supervisor/graduate student contract.*

What the model produced. The model drafted the initial structure and wording of Sections 1–9 and Appendix A, including the four principles governing AI use and the table of permitted, restricted, and prohibited uses. On subsequent instruction, it condensed the draft, inserted the table of contents, reduced the type size, and revised the prose for register and spelling consistency.

What the author contributed. The author specified the four principles to be emphasized and the scope of the document, revised the title, the identifying table, the commitments of both parties, the table of uses, and Appendix A, and determined the final content of every section. The author is responsible for the substance of the agreement as adopted.

Verification. Each section was read and edited before adoption; no output was accepted without review. The prompts and the unedited model output are retained by the author and are available on request.

Use: Feel free to use and adapt the agreement as is. Acknowledgment is appreciated but not required.